

Agent washing. Ask before you buy.

Gartner estimates that of the thousands of vendors pitching agentic AI, only about **130** are doing anything genuinely agentic – and predicts over **40%** of agentic AI projects will be cancelled by the end of 2027. An assistant suggests and a person decides; an agent acts on its own. Know which one you're buying before you sign.

THE HEADLINE NUMBERS

Gartner · 25 Jun 2025

GARTNER ESTIMATE

~130

of the thousands of vendors pitching agentic AI are doing anything genuinely agentic

GARTNER FORECAST

40%+

of agentic AI projects predicted cancelled by the end of 2027

Gartner, press release, 25 June 2025. The 130 figure is an estimate and the 40%+ figure is a forecast. Cited reasons: escalating costs, unclear business value, inadequate risk controls.

WAITS, OR ACTS

the question to ask

A

Assistant

Suggests, then waits.

- A human reads it, decides, and clicks approve. Every time.

B

Agent

Decides, then acts.

- A human finds out afterward, if at all. The price you are quoted assumes this one.

WHERE THIS SITS

two of the five layers



Governance: would you delegate this decision at all. Controls: what catches and undoes it when it is wrong. The three reasons Gartner cites for the cancellations (cost, unclear value, weak risk controls) are Governance and Controls questions.

Monday morning

BEFORE THE NEXT DEMO

Ask two questions out loud, before you look at a single slide of the pitch: **name the decision** this system will make and act on without a human, and **name who owns the outcome** the day it gets that decision wrong.

Self-check: if nobody can answer, or the answer turns into a feature list, what you're being sold is an assistant priced as an agent.

OPERATOR INSIGHT · EPISODE 9

"An assistant waits for a human. An agent acts without one. Most 'agentic' products are the first, sold at the price of the second."

"Your AI maturity will never exceed your operational maturity."

Free

Run your next vendor evaluation against the five layers before you sign. [vihrenlabs.gumroad.com/l/rmkje](https://vihrenlabs.com/l/rmkje)